Er musste das Wissen aufheben

van Fraassen on the priority of the manifest image

Hans Halvorson

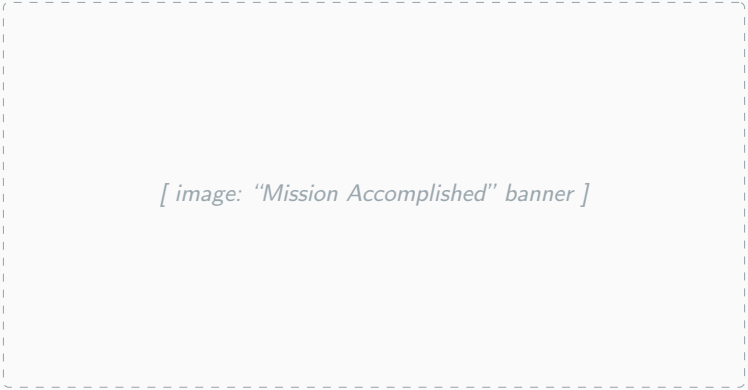
Schock Prize Symposium

Princeton University

Mission accomplished?

Mission accomplished?

Mission accomplished?



The mission: a new way of doing philosophy

"I do not think we need new theories in philosophy.
But . . . we must change, or change back,
the way we do philosophy."

technical work, yes — but in aid of an *authentic, engaged project in the world*, conscious of its own limits

Not that kind of anti-realist

The expected story: an "anti-realist" makes science *mere instrument* — with nothing to say about who we are.

But Bas never abandons "know thyself."

science still has yield for the *gnothi seauton* project

Where we are going

1. The Sellarsian challenge
2. Bas's response
3. A Danish story
4. *Er musste das Wissen aufheben*

The Sellarsian challenge

Pittsburgh, c. 1960

Grünbaum · Sellars · Kockelmans

the problematic of a career is set

Sellars (1962)

"Philosophy and the Scientific Image of Man"

in the air in Pittsburgh — witness *The Scientific Image*

Two images

Manifest

persons · colours · reasons

[Eddington's table:
solid, brown]

Scientific

particles · fields · the void

[Eddington's table:
mostly empty space]

Sellars's pink ice cube



pink all the way through — but nowhere in the scientific image

Priority?

Sellars on the fence

"To the extent that the manifest does not survive in the synoptic view, to that extent man himself would not survive."

— a "stereoscopic vision"

Closing the circle

Quine · Shimony · Lewis · Albert & Loewer · Dennett

an old ambition ⟵ **Spinoza**

What kind of *fact*
is “priority”?

A stance — not a discovery

To rank the images is not to report a finding.

It is to declare what you value.

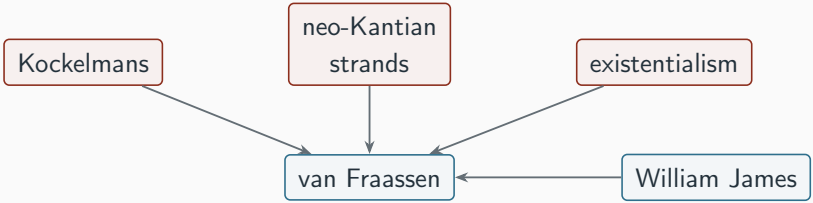
What was Bas's response?

The uncharitable reading

"Bas is really one of those 1960s existentialists who just doesn't want to be told what to do."

— an unnamed colleague

The European van Fraassen



(Høffding and James were friends)

“The Manifest Image and the Scientific Image”

The dichotomy is confused from the start.

- an “image” is not to be found *within* the scientific image
- Sellars speaks from a place his story has no room for

cf. Putnam on Williams’s “absolute conception”

The Empirical Stance: a shift

image $\longrightarrow$ objectifying inquiry

not a picture *inside* us
but a *mode of approach* — one that removes the subject

Two roads to the same critique





the subject cannot be eliminated from inquiry

The Danish story

Hegel

objectifying inquiry *on steroids*

the System with no remainder, no open place

- not adequate to the natural sciences
- not adequate to the richness of life

γνῶθι σεαυτόν

man is still *becoming* — not yet a god

Kierkegaard

The speculative philosopher is forgetful.

what he has forgotten is *who he himself is*

Rasmus Nielsen (1809–1884)

Kierkegaard's mantle → philosophy of science

objektiveringsloven

the law of objectification

Harald Høffding

- no objectification is ever *final*
- science cannot be purged of its *anthropocentric* elements

"When will the last anthropomorphism be found?"

Niels Bohr

complementarity

= Høffding's relationist epistemology,

physically implemented

the subject stays in the picture — by necessity

Back to Bas's mission

Ich musste das Wissen
aufheben

Not “restrict”

“restricting” knowledge $\Rightarrow$ two eyes, two worlds

aufheben: cancel · preserve · lift up

Wissen is a *moment* — not the telos

Kierkegaard's correction

The dialectic is not out there.

It is in each one of us.

tilegne

to appropriate — to make one's own

The mission

Not a doctrine to be axiomatized,
but an example to be *appropriated*.

Bas — mission accomplished.